Chapter 1

FLUTTER

In this chapter, the procedure for identifying flutter derivatives using both the Single-Frequency and Multi-Frequency methods from CFD simulations is introduced. The calculation of the critical wind speed using the aerodynamic and structural properties of the bridge deck is then presented. A Python tool is developed to perform these tasks and validated against benchmark results.

1.1 Identification of Aerodynamic Forces

Aerodynamic forces are obtained using forced-motion CFD simulations. A 2-D cross-section of the bridge deck is modelled in a virtual wind tunnel with appropriate boundary conditions. The bridge cross-section is then oscillated sinusoidally in the vertical (heave) direction according to

$$h(t) = h_0 \sin(\omega t), \tag{1.1}$$

$$\dot{h}(t) = \omega h_0 \cos(\omega t), \tag{1.2}$$

where h_0 is the maximum amplitude of the applied heave motion and ω is the angular frequency of the applied heave motion. Since no pitch motion is applied, $\alpha = \dot{\alpha} = 0$, and the aerodynamic lift force and pitching moment simplify to

$$L_{ae} = \frac{1}{2}\rho U^2 B \left[K H_1^* \frac{\dot{h}}{U} + K^2 H_4^* \frac{h}{B} \right] \qquad \text{(Scanlan formulation)}, \tag{1.3}$$

$$M_{ae} = \frac{1}{2}\rho U^2 B^2 \left[K A_1^* \frac{\dot{h}}{U} + K^2 A_4^* \frac{h}{B} \right] \qquad \text{(Scanlan formulation)}. \tag{1.4}$$

Under the small-amplitude assumption (small h_0), Scanlan's linearisation implies that the aerodynamic lift and moment measured from CFD take the sinusoidal form

$$L_{ae} = B_0 \sin(\omega t + \phi) \;=\; B_1 \cos(\omega t) + B_2 \sin(\omega t), \tag{1.5}$$

$$M_{ae} = C_0 \sin(\omega t + \Phi) \;=\; C_1 \cos(\omega t) + C_2 \sin(\omega t). \tag{1.6}$$

1.2 Calculation of Flutter Derivatives

The flutter derivatives are determined by equating the lift force from the Scanlan formulation with the CFD result and matching cosine and sine coefficients, which gives

$$\frac{1}{2}\rho U^2 B \left[K H_1^* + K^2 H_4^* \right] = B_1 \cos(\omega t) + B_2 \sin(\omega t), \tag{1.7}$$

$$\frac{1}{2}\rho U^2 B^2 \left[K A_1^* + K^2 A_4^* \right] = C_1 \cos(\omega t) + C_2 \sin(\omega t). \tag{1.8}$$

From this, the flutter derivatives for heave excitation are obtained as

$$H_1^* = \frac{2B_1}{\rho\,\omega^2 B^2 h_0}, \qquad H_4^* = \frac{2B_2}{\rho\,\omega^2 B^2 h_0}, \tag{1.9}$$

$$A_1^* = \frac{2C_1}{\rho\,\omega^2 B^3 h_0}, \qquad A_4^* = \frac{2C_2}{\rho\,\omega^2 B^3 h_0}. \tag{1.10}$$

The same procedure is repeated with pitch (torsional) excitation to obtain the remaining flutter derivatives H_2^*, H_3^*, A_2^*, and A_3^*. Consequently, a total of two forced-motion simulations (one heave, one pitch) are required to obtain a complete set of eight flutter derivatives at each reduced velocity.

1.3 Calculation of Critical Wind Speed

Equations of Motion

The coupled two-degree-of-freedom equations of motion for the bridge deck are

$$m\Big(\ddot{h} + 2\omega_h\zeta_h\dot{h} + \omega_h^2 h\Big) = L_{ae}, \tag{1.11}$$

$$I_\alpha\big(\ddot{\alpha} + 2\omega_\alpha\zeta_\alpha\dot{\alpha} + \omega_\alpha^2\alpha\big) = M_{ae}, \tag{1.12}$$

where the aerodynamic forces are given by the Scanlan formulation:

$$L_{ae} = \frac{1}{2}\rho U^2 B\left[KH_1^*\frac{\dot{h}}{U} + KH_2^*\frac{B\dot{\alpha}}{U} + K^2H_3^*\alpha + K^2H_4^*\frac{h}{B}\right], \tag{1.13}$$

$$M_{ae} = \frac{1}{2}\rho U^2 B^2\left[KA_1^*\frac{\dot{h}}{U} + KA_2^*\frac{B\dot{\alpha}}{U} + K^2A_3^*\alpha + K^2A_4^*\frac{h}{B}\right]. \tag{1.14}$$

Matrix Form (Time Domain)

Substituting the aerodynamic forces into the equations of motion and rearranging yields the matrix system

$$\begin{aligned}&\begin{bmatrix} m & 0 \\ 0 & I \end{bmatrix}\begin{Bmatrix} \ddot{h} \\ \ddot{\alpha} \end{Bmatrix} + \begin{bmatrix} C_h & 0 \\ 0 & C_\alpha \end{bmatrix}\begin{Bmatrix} \dot{h} \\ \dot{\alpha} \end{Bmatrix} + \begin{bmatrix} K_h & 0 \\ 0 & K_\alpha \end{bmatrix}\begin{Bmatrix} h \\ \alpha \end{Bmatrix} \\ &- \frac{1}{2}\rho K^2\left(\begin{bmatrix} H_1^* & BH_2^* \\ A_1^* & BA_2^* \end{bmatrix}\begin{Bmatrix} \dot{h} \\ \dot{\alpha} \end{Bmatrix} + \begin{bmatrix} H_4^* & H_3^* \\ A_4^* & BA_3^* \end{bmatrix}\begin{Bmatrix} h \\ \alpha \end{Bmatrix}\right) = \begin{Bmatrix} 0 \\ 0 \end{Bmatrix}.\end{aligned} \tag{1.15}$$

Frequency-Domain Eigenvalue Problem

Assuming harmonic motion $h = e^{i\omega t}$ and $\alpha = e^{i\omega t}$, and transforming to the frequency domain, the system becomes

$$\left(-\omega^2 \begin{bmatrix} m & 0 \\ 0 & I \end{bmatrix} + i\omega \begin{bmatrix} C_h & 0 \\ 0 & C_\alpha \end{bmatrix} + \begin{bmatrix} K_h & 0 \\ 0 & K_\alpha \end{bmatrix} - \frac{1}{2}\rho K^2 \begin{bmatrix} H_4^* - H_1^* & BH_3^* - BH_2^* \\ A_4^* - A_1^* & BA_3^* - BA_2^* \end{bmatrix}\right) \begin{Bmatrix} h \\ \alpha \end{Bmatrix} = \begin{Bmatrix} 0 \\ 0 \end{Bmatrix}, \tag{1.16}$$

which is of the standard form

$$-\omega^2 M + i\omega C + K = 0. \tag{1.17}$$

Here $\omega = \omega_r + i\omega_i$ is a complex frequency: the real part ω_r is the oscillation frequency and the imaginary part ω_i governs the growth or decay of the response.

Stability Criterion

Because structural damping is present the problem is a complex quadratic eigenvalue problem, which is linearised as follows:

$$\left(\begin{bmatrix} 0 & K \\ K & iC \end{bmatrix} - \omega \begin{bmatrix} K & 0 \\ 0 & -M \end{bmatrix}\right) \begin{pmatrix} X \\ \omega X \end{pmatrix} = \begin{Bmatrix} 0 \\ 0 \end{Bmatrix}, \qquad \text{i.e.} \quad A - \lambda B = 0. \tag{1.18}$$

The sign of ω_i determines stability:

- $\omega_i > 0$: $h = h_0\, e^{i\omega_r t} \cdot e^{-\omega_i t}$ — stable (amplitude decays).
- $\omega_i < 0$: $h = h_0\, e^{i\omega_r t} \cdot e^{+|\omega_i| t}$ — unstable (amplitude grows; flutter onset).

A Python tool has been developed to solve this linearised eigenvalue problem and identify the critical wind speed.

Determining the critical wind speed is an iterative process:

1. A reduced velocity $U_r = U/(fB)$ is selected.
2. Flutter derivatives corresponding to that reduced velocity are interpolated from the flutter-derivative functions.
3. The linearised eigenvalue problem is solved for ω.
4. If the system is stable, the reduced velocity is increased and the process repeats until the system first becomes unstable.
5. The actual critical wind speed is then recovered from

$$U_c = U_{r,c}\, \frac{\omega_r}{2\pi}\, B, \tag{1.19}$$

where $U_{r,c}$ is the reduced critical velocity and ω_r is the real part of the eigenfrequency at that point.

1.4 Multi-Frequency Method

In the single-frequency method, the forced-motion oscillation (heave or pitch) is applied at one frequency at a time, yielding one set of flutter derivatives per simulation. In the **multi-frequency method**, several frequencies are superposed in a single forced-motion simulation:

$$h(t) = \sum_{k=1}^{N} h_{0,k} \sin(\omega_k t + \phi_k). \tag{1.20}$$

Under the assumption of aerodynamic linearity, the total aerodynamic response is the superposition of the responses at each individual frequency. Consequently, N sets of flutter derivatives can be extracted from a single simulation by applying a Fourier decomposition of the measured aerodynamic forces at each frequency component ω_k.

The procedures for calculating the flutter derivatives (Section 2) and the critical wind speed (Section 3) are identical for both the single- and multi-frequency methods. The only difference lies in the identification of aerodynamic forces (Section 1), where multiple frequency components are excited simultaneously rather than one at a time. Figures 1.1 and 1.2 illustrate the workflow for the two methods.

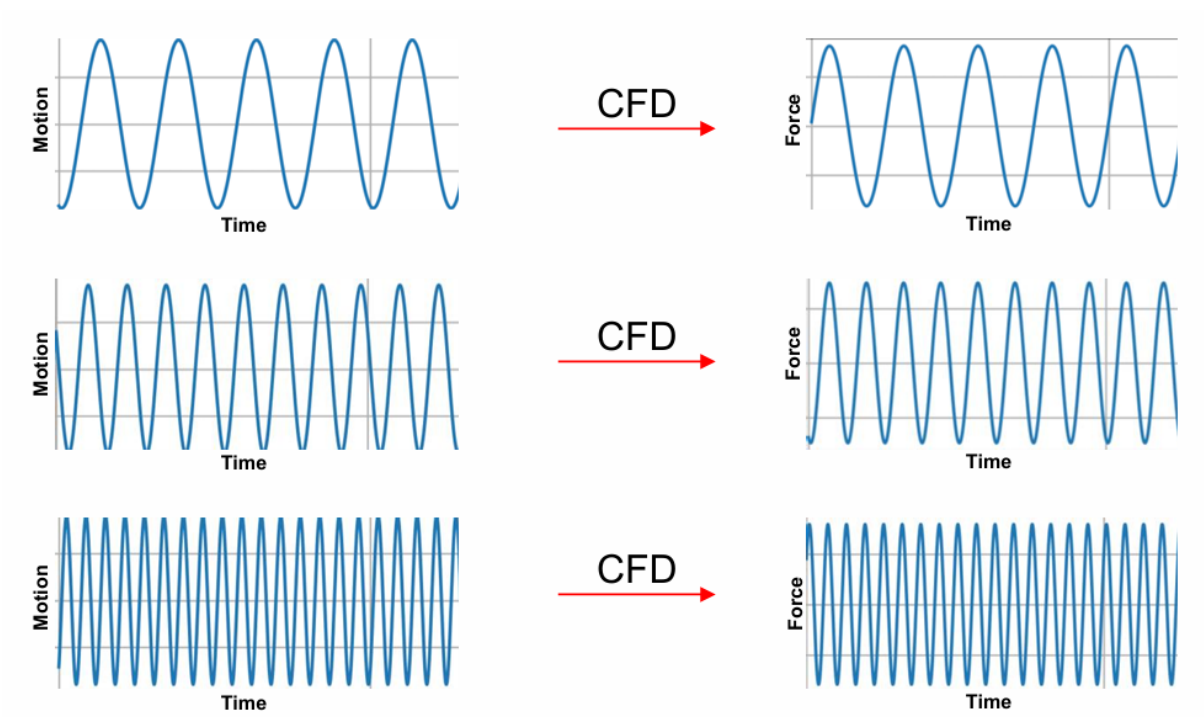

Figure 1.1: Workflow for the single-frequency method.

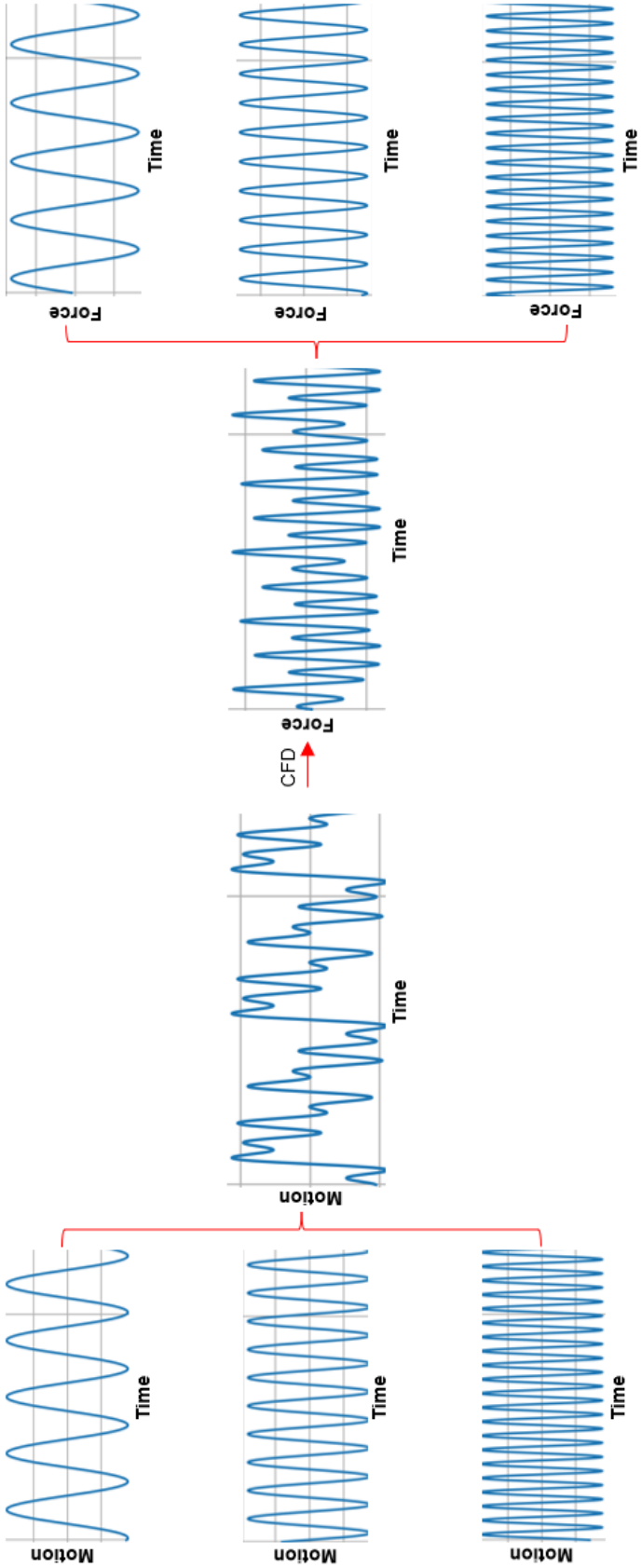

Figure 1.2: Workflow for the multi-frequency method.